

How much of UAE seaborne trade still depends on the Strait of Hormuz?

UAE port activity during the 2026 closure of the strait (1 March – 25 September), from IMF PortWatch vessel-tracking (AIS) estimates validated against official port figures. Cargo-vessel transits registered by AIS fell from 70–100 a day in 2025 to 3–13 a day.

BOTTOM LINE

- FINDING** Seven months into the closure, UAE ports moved just over a quarter of the tonnage of the historical reference: **27.7%** across all segments, and only **16.1%** for containers.
- FINDING** Fujairah and Khor Fakkan, outside the strait, took diverted containers but offset only about **4%** of the Gulf-coast container loss. Across all cargo they lost volume themselves (**~23.7 Mt**), mainly in Fujairah's tankers.
- FINDING** At current scale they cannot replace Jebel Ali: declared container capacity is **~30%** of Jebel Ali's, Khor Fakkan's tonnes fell 22% after early August (cause unknown) and rail freight to Fujairah began on 27 Sep.
- The "Zero Hormuz" goal has no public indicator. This monitor offers one, by cargo segment, refreshed weekly from open data.

27.7%

UAE port activity preserved, all cargo

Range 26.2–28.2% (5 baselines)

16.1%

Container activity preserved

Range 14.5–16.2%

4.2%

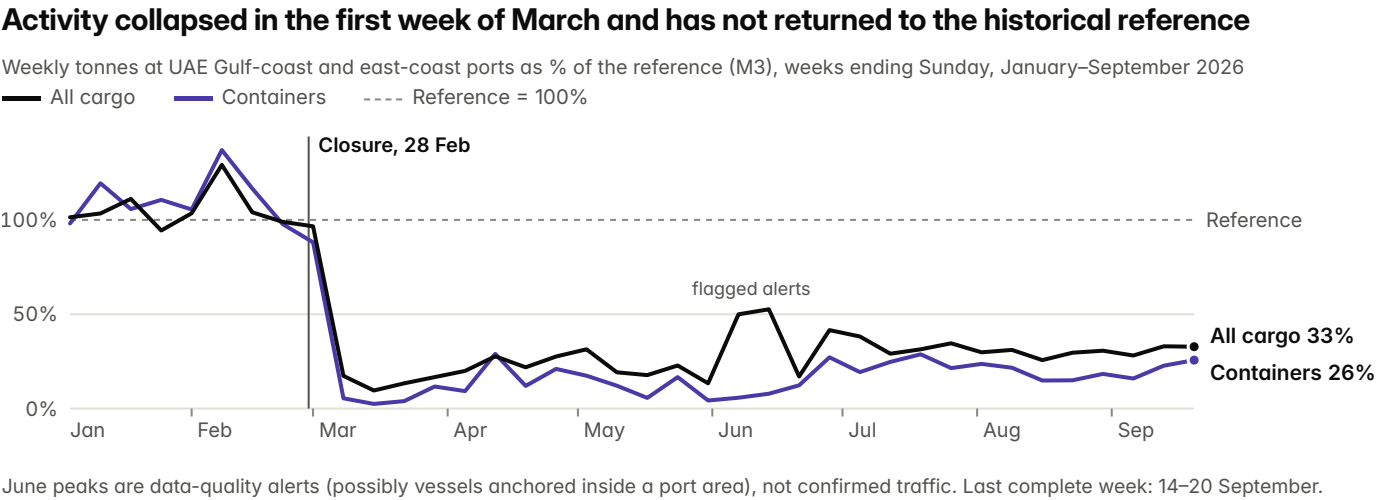
Share of the Gulf-coast container loss offset by the east coast

Range 4.2–4.7%

211 Mt

Gap vs the historical reference, all cargo

Range 206–227 Mt



Where the volume went, by cargo segment

Million tonnes (Mt), 1 March – 25 September 2026, reference M3. Changes are actual minus reference.

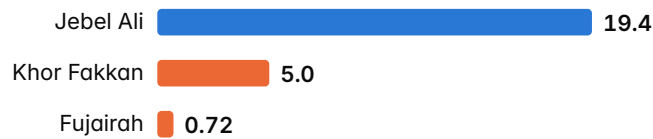
Cargo segment	Reference	Observed	Gulf coast change	East coast change	Gap vs reference	Activity preserved (M3) · range M1–M5
Containers	118.7	19.2	–104.0	+4.4	99.6	16.1% 14.5–16.2
General cargo + RoRo	5.3	3.2	–2.5	+0.3	2.2	59.3% 39.4–59.3
Dry bulk	58.5	26.8	–33.6	+1.9	31.7	45.8% 41.3–45.8
Tankers	109.5	31.7	–47.5	–30.3	77.8	29.0% 29.0–34.0
All cargo	292.0	80.8	–187.5	–23.7	211.3	27.7% 26.2–28.2

Gap = difference in activity relative to the historical reference; its recovery and possible redistribution are assessed through separate scenarios. It does not measure unmet demand or required capacity. Ranges = minimum and maximum across baselines M1–M5: they show the choice of reference, not confidence intervals. Backtest error is ~9% for Gulf-coast containers (M3) but 95–235% for east-coast containers, so the east-coast offset (4.2–4.7%) is an order of magnitude, not a precise figure. AIS measurement error is separate and not quantified. Oman (comparison only): attributable volume not identified, no compensation credited.

Why the east coast cannot replace Jebel Ali

1 · SIZE

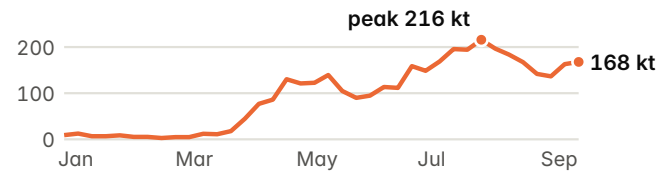
About 30% of Jebel Ali's container capacity



FINDING Declared container capacity, million TEU a year: the two east-coast ports add up to 5.7, against 19.4 at Jebel Ali.

3 · PACE VS DECLARED CAPACITY

Khor Fakkan peaked in early August, then fell



FINDING Container tonnes (kt), 4-week average. July: ~65,000 TEU a week (operator), a pace equal to ~97% of the declared 3.5 M TEU a year, not measured occupancy. Peak 216 kt (2 Aug), then -22% by 20 Sep despite expansion to 5 M TEU; cause not identified.

FINDING At its best four-week run, the east coast moved about 7% of the container tonnes of an average pre-closure Jebel Ali week (Jan 2025 – Feb 2026). Drewry (March): no mix of alternative ports and land logistics fully replaces Hormuz in the short term.

What this means for the "Zero Hormuz" strategy

FINDING Containers carry the deepest dependence. Container activity stayed 84% below reference; Jebel Ali ran near 13% of reference in Aug–Sep. **HYPOTHESIS** It follows the strait, not its own capacity (preliminarily supported).

FINDING Oman is not yet a measurable outlet. No diversion to Sohar, Salalah or Duqm stands out from normal noise; crediting it needs customs or corridor evidence.

FINDING Value is not volume. UAE non-oil foreign trade grew 13.1% in H1 2026 while container tonnage collapsed. **HYPOTHESIS** Gold and high-value air cargo explain most of it (untested).

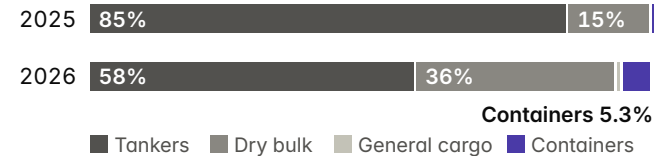
Where to investigate next: rail and truck volumes between the east coast and Gulf-side hubs, Khor Fakkan's throughput after expansion, and Fujairah's container berths. The monitor informs these decisions; it does not size investments.

Method

Daily import + export tonnes (AIS-based estimates) for the 15 UAE port areas in PortWatch and three Omani ports, 2019–2026. **Activity preserved** = (Gulf + east-coast actual) ÷ (Gulf + east-coast reference). **Reference M3** = average of the same weekday 52 and 104 weeks earlier; four other baselines give the range. Backtest on three pre-closure windows, median weekly WAPE: M4 15.0%, M3 16.2%, M1 20.3%. **Limits:** estimates, not customs records; Hormuz transits used for trend only (PortWatch 31 vs Lloyd's List 73, 10–16 Aug); air, land and pipeline trade not covered.

2 · SPECIALIZATION

Fujairah is an oil and bulk port



FINDING Share of Fujairah's tonnes, 1 Mar – 25 Sep: containers rose only from 0.1% in 2025 to 5.3% in 2026.

4 · LAND CONNECTION

Rail freight began on 27 September

FINDING **Rail:** Etihad Rail's Abu Dhabi–Fujairah freight service started on 27 Sep 2026, three times a week; Khor Fakkan is not on it. **Trucks:** too few, and multimodal routes costly and slow (AGBI, March). **Waits:** median anchorage 9.3 days at Fujairah, 4.8 at Khor Fakkan, 2–8 Aug (Portcast via Nautica; low confidence).

HYPOTHESIS Inland links, not quay capacity alone, limit what the east coast can serve.

Validation against official figures

Check (containers)	PortWatch	Official
Jebel Ali, Q2 2026 (DP World)	-90.9%	-90.1%
Jebel Ali, H1 2026 (DP World)	-58.9%	-59.5%
Khor Fakkan, Jun–Jul vs 2025 (Gulftainer)	×11.3	×8.1
AD Ports, Q2 2026 (different port sets)	-77.4%	-65.0%

Tonnes vs TEU: compared only as % changes, never as levels.

Figure notes. Period 1 Mar – 25 Sep 2026 unless stated; estimated import + export tonnes (IMF PortWatch, retrieved 3 Oct 2026) or official TEU where marked. Gulf coast = Jebel Ali, Khalifa, Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Sharjah, Ajman, Umm al Qaiwain, Mina Saqr, Al Hamriyah, Jabal Az Zannah–Ruways, Jebel Dhanna, Das Island, Zirku Island; east coast = Fujairah, Khor Fakkan. Capacities, rail, trucking and waits come from operators and press. Finding = measured, with source; Hypothesis = explanation pending test. Code and data: Zero Hormuz Monitor v0.3.1. Independent analysis, not affiliated with the IMF or any port operator.